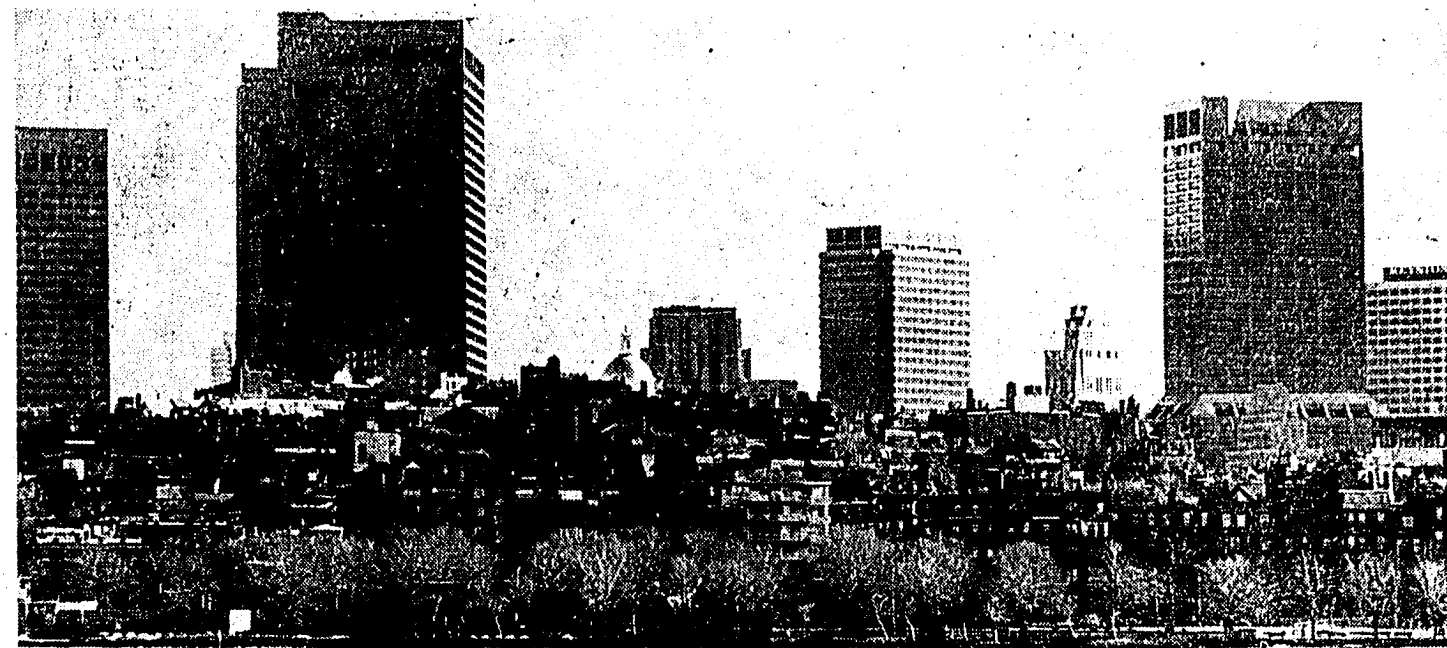




Boston's high-rise skyscrapers loom large on the skyline, out of proportion to the surrounding cityscape. (Globe photo by Paul Connell)

High-rise isn't exactly high life

Two big new development proposals are raising again the controversy of high-rise building in Boston.

As of this writing, the fate of both projects — the Park Plaza complex fronting the Public Garden, and a 47-story office tower planned for 60 State Street next to Faneuil Hall — is in doubt. That fact in itself is a symptom of a new concern about the impact of these structures on the life of the city.

While Community Affairs Comr. Lewis S. W. Crampton ponders Park Plaza and Mayor Kevin White tries to resolve his doubts over 60 State Street, it's a good time for everyone to take another look at the issue of high-rise in Boston and whether, or how, it benefits anyone other than its backers.

The question is especially timely in view of the recent high-rise referendum in San Francisco, which, although failing to control the business district, succeeded in imposing a 40-foot height limit on the remaining 90 percent of the city, a similar effort is under way in Cambridge.

Also pertinent is the high level of public dissatisfaction with such new Boston landmarks as One Beacon Street, a leviathan grossly out of scale with nearby Beacon Hill and Pemberton Square, or the pompous and dull Federal Reserve Building, or the architecturally even less distinguished One Boston Place.

ARCHITECTURE / ROBERT CAMPBELL

Ignoring the city at their feet by failing to include so much as a restaurant on the ground floor because it might spoil the "corporate image," such towers instead often place private dining clubs on the top floor to serve the few. The building becomes a kind of diagram of the elitist corporate structure that supports it.

If some affronted member of the public starts to ask questions — questions about dark, crowded streets, jammed subways, the ugliness of the towers, their lack of scale or relation to the older parts of the city, the high winds at sidewalk level, the lack of shops or any other consideration for the pedestrian, the destruction of good older buildings (this week, Raymond's on Washington Street), the boredom of a single-use, all-office neighborhood — if these questions are raised, as increasingly they are, and the suggestion is made that the towers might at least be spaced a bit farther apart, the answer returns like a rehearsed catechism from the developers and their allies in government.

High buildings, these people tell us raise the tax base, and in doing so, they relieve the tax pressure on the rest of us. They create new jobs — blue collar during construction, white collar afterwards. They're good for the city, they stimulate growth.

The trouble is, no one ever bothers to investigate these claims. No one has ever done a cost-benefit study of the effect of high-rise development in Boston.

Such studies have been made in other cities, though, and the results do not support the conventional wisdom.

For example, in San Francisco, where the anti-high-rise battles have been fiercest, studies—admittedly partisan—revealed the following:

— From 1950 to 1970, while the skyscrapers were rising in downtown San Francisco, downtown's contribution in taxes was going not up but down. In 1950 the district provided 31 percent of the city's property taxes; in 1970, only 24 percent.

—Meanwhile, the cost of city services to the high-rise district was skyrocketing. In 1970 the district gave the city \$63 million in all forms of tax, but took back \$68 million in services. Far from subsidizing the homeowner, the high-rise development was adding to his burdens.

—Although the high-rise construction did provide jobs for the building industry, these amounted to only one-fifth the number of other blue-collar jobs lost to the city as industry fled from spiralling land costs.

—A net increase did occur in white collar jobs in the high-rise district, but there was no increase in the number of San Franciscans holding such jobs. Apparently, the whole increase was accounted for by out-of-town commuters, whose presence in the city, where they paid no tax, only added to the load on city services.

A similar cost-benefit study was done for the city of Toronto by an independent consultant. Focussing on high-rise housing, it came to the same conclusion, and recommended to the city that it discourage such development.

In the face of the doubts such studies raise, one can only wonder at the continuing glow of pride with which developers and their advocates tell us how their efforts are going to raise the tax base and provide jobs, and how these benefits will be more than enough to offset any environmental inconveniences.

Yet, from Revere Beach to Kendall Square to Park Plaza, these old justifications are still put forward, without anyone even feeling the need to support them with really comprehensive data.

It would be too simple to conclude from this that high-rise development is always or even usually bad.

What we can say, however, is that the case for high-rise, even on strict economic grounds, can no longer be taken for granted.